(a)). In non-metallic elements, their atomic radius is known as **Covalent radius.** It is defined as **half the distance between the adjacent nuclei of two covalently bonded atoms of the same element in a molecule** (Figure 8.2 (b)). For example, let us consider H_2 molecule. The distance between the two hydrogen nuclei of the molecule is 0.74 Å. So its covalent radius is 0.74/2 = 0.37 Å.

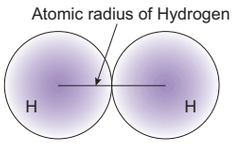


Figure 8.3 Atomic radius

When you look at the variation of the atomic radii in the periodic table, there are two distinct trends. Along the period, from left to right, the atomic radius of the elements decreases whereas along the groups, from the top to bottom, the atomic radius increases. The increase, down a group, is due to the increase in the valence shell number down the group. As the shell number increases, the distance between the valence shell and the nucleus increases. In contrast, when you observe along the period, the shell number remains the same but the number of protons (i.e. atomic number) increases. More and more positive charges impose a strong attraction over the electrons and thus the electron cloud shrinks towards the nucleus, which results in the decrease in the atomic size. Figure 8.4 shows how the atomic radius decreases from lithium to boron.

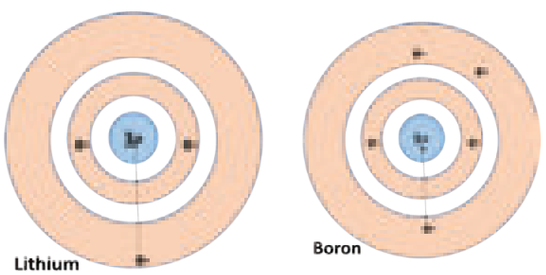


Figure 8.4 Variation of atomic radius

8.3.2 Ionic Radii

It is defined as the distance from the centre of the nucleus of the ion upto the point where it exerts its influence on the electron cloud of the ion. You know that ions are formed when an atom lose or gain electrons. When a neutral atom loses an electron, it becomes a positively charged ion called **cation,** whereas the gain of an electron by a neutral atom forms a negatively charged ion called **anion.** The size of the ions is important to determine their behaviours in solutions and the structure of ionic solids. The size of a cation is always smaller than its corresponding neutral atom. But, the anion is larger than its neutral atom.

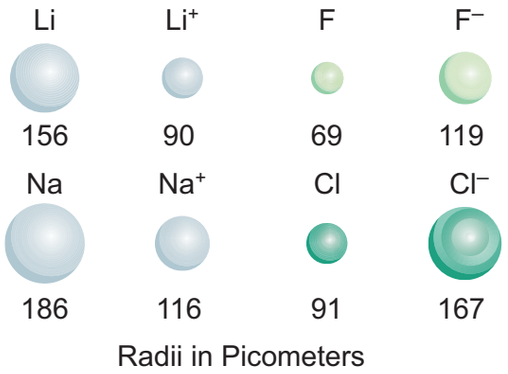


Figure 8.5 Relative ionic radii of cation and anion

Note: As the positive charge increases the size of the cation decreases
As the negative charge increases the size of the anion increases

For instance, lithium and sodium lose the single electron from their outermost energy level to form cations. The ions so formed are smaller because the remaining electrons are at a inner cells and attracted more strongly by the nucleus. Fluorine and chlorine become negative ions by gaining an electron. When electrons are added, the charge on the nucleus is not great enough to hold the increased number of electrons as closely as it holds the electrons in the neutral atom. So, **as seen in atomic radius, ionic radii also decrease along the period from left to right and increase down the group.**

8.3.3 Ionisation Energy

Ionisation energy is the minimum energy required to remove an electron from

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